

YOUR LITTLE SECRET

A Short Film

By

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SCENE 1**EXT. OPEN FIELD, BANGLADESH, JULY 1971-MIDNIGHT**

5 Pakistani soldiers are sitting around a bonfire in the middle of the open field. Other than a handful of trees scattered here and there, there is nothing else of note on the screen, except for an unmarked village located approximately 500 meters from the bonfire. The soldiers are here as lookouts, and as such, it is vital for them to stay awake the entire night and monitor the area. Meanwhile, to pass the time, the characters are exchanging stories with each other. In the beginning of this scene, FARUK is in the middle of excitedly relaying a story, and JAVED, MIRZA and SALMAN are intently listening to him. AHMAD, who is noticeably younger than the rest of the group, also listens to the story, but he sits dejectedly at one corner.

FARUK:

(Excited)

And then, I kid you not, this man lunges at me with his pitchfork!

MIRZA:

(Laughing)

Oh come on, you're just pulling my leg! There's no way in hell that actually happened!

FARUK:

No, seriously, I'm telling you! The damn guy still had the gall to try and take me down!

SALMAN:

(Playful)

With a bullet in his head?

FARUK:

Yeah, with a bullet in his head!

JAVED:

(Playful)

You must've missed.

FARUK:

(Defensive)

No! I did not! I shot him, right in the temple. Dead center.

JAVED:

Right...

I feel like there's a joke somewhere in there, between your aim supposedly being dead center and the guy not being dead, but then again, dumbasses like you might just miss that.

The mirthful band of soldiers begin laughing, except for FARUK who appears annoyed. AHMAD does not appear to be laughing either.

MIRZA:

(Laughing)

Yeah, it would probably go right over his head..

Just like Faruk's bullet went over that guy's!

The laughter grows louder, FARUK gives in and joins the group in laughing at himself. AHMAD remains mostly unmoved, however he does break a little smile indicating that he too found the joke funny, despite his forlorn mood.

FARUK:

Okay, I get it! You lot think I'm making stuff up like Salman usually does, bu-

SALMAN:

(Interrupting FARUK)

Hey! Don't drag me into this!

FARUK: (CONT'D)

-But, I swear to God, that is exactly what happened. I shot his family first, he got all worked up about it, he picked up his pitchfork, and was about to do something dumb; so I shot him, clean on the head. The body hit the ground, and 5 seconds later...

MIRZA:

And 5 seconds later, he's up and at it again, trying to skewer you, eh?

JAVED:

(Laughing)

Sounds to me, that even the Bangalees figured out you're full of shit, Faruk.

SALMAN:

(Appearing ironically serious)

You know, at least when I blabber on about my exploits, I at least try to make it sound like I'm not lying through my teeth!

The groups breaks up into laughter once again. AHMAD finally seems to be enjoying the banter between his comrades, however he still remains relatively reserved.

FARUK:

(Sighing)

Whatever, believe me, don't believe me. Doesn't matter, I know what I saw. Who even cares what you idiots think?

SALMAN:

(Immediately after FARUK)

You do.

FARUK:

(Playfully, to his comrades)

Shut up!

FARUK: (CONT'D)

Anyway, just change the subject already.

Say, Sergeant, what have you been upto?

JAVED:

Normal stuff; you know, liberating places, maintaining peace and whatnot.

But most importantly...

The sergeant trails off mid-sentence and appears to stare off into the distance, as if lost in deep thought. After a few seconds of silence, FARUK finally says something.

FARUK:

Ummm..."But most importantly" what?

JAVED:

(Laughing again)

But most importantly, I have not been missing headshots and almost getting mauled by farmers armed with pointy sticks!

FARUK:

(Playful)

Oh, come on!

The joke's dead already. Stop trying to bring it back!

JAVED:

(Suddenly turning a bit somber)

Yeah, maybe you're right. But speaking of returning from the dead-

FARUK:

(Annoyed)

Don't you dare bring up the farmer I killed!

JAVED:

(Laughing)

I wasn't going too.

JAVED: (CONT'D)

But back when I was stationed in Tangail about a month ago, I heard about this girl who has apparently been haunting the unit stationed there.

SALMAN:

I'm sorry, "Haunting"?

JAVED:

Yeah. The guys said they captured some girl named Amena from the village they were ordered to raze. Thought it would just be a waste to simply kill her off, so they kept her for a week or so. Did all sorts of nasty shit with her, and once they were done, chopped her head off and then disposed of the body in the river.

And ever since then, the headless wench has allegedly been visiting them every night.

FARUK:

Huh. And I assume these nightly visits by Amena were not of the 'fun kind'?

JAVED:

Nope, they were not.

Most of her former captors are now very much dead.

And though the story is mostly just a bunch of crap, all those deaths really hit the unit's morale. So, the guys who were still alive ended up getting posted elsewhere.

MIRZA:

Nice.

The group is caught off-guard by MIRZA's inappropriate response, but mostly laugh it off because they also find the response funny. AHMAD however does not seem to appreciate the joke, and appears slightly offended at MIRZA's disregard for human life, both Pakistani and Bengali.

JAVED:

(Joking)

A bunch of our comrades got assassinated by a specter from beyond the grave, and your response is 'Nice'?

MIRZA:

Well, it was more because Amena, even though she's a literal supernatural agent of death, has like an effective range of operation. Just move out of Tangail, And she can't get you anymore!

MIRZA's comment about the absurdity of the Ghost of Amena being confined to a specific area manages to get a little chuckle out of everyone.

MIRZA: (CONT'D)

But also, you can't exactly expect us to be bummed out about death, Sergeant.

(Pointing to AHMAD).

We're not like Mr. Sensitive over here. Already seen way too much of that, nothing left under the sun to bother us anymore.

AHMAD's lack of participation in the conversation seems to pique the interest of JAVED. He turns to AHMAD, and speaks to him directly.

JAVED:

Oh yeah, the new kid.

Still giving us the silent treatment, huh?

SALMAN:

(In a concerned tone)

He's been like this since yesterday's operation. I thought bringing him here with us would lighten his mood a bit...

But that doesn't seem to have worked out.

FARUK:

(Annoyed)

Imagine feeling guilty about killing Bangalees, grow the hell up!

AHMAD:

It just felt so wrong.

FARUK:

(In a mocking tone)

Good Lord!

"It felt wrong"; With pathetic excuses like you as soliders, we might just lose the war!

AHMAD's apparent concern and sympathy towards the enemy does not sit well with FARUK. He gradually appears to grow angrier the longer he listens to the conversation. MIRZA shares FARUK's sentiment, but is intent on maintaining his composure. AHMAD feels shame for having suddenly offended his comrades who are much older and more experienced than him, but is not willing to back down without a fight. SALMAN and JAVED decide not to interfere in the matter for the moment, and act only as an audience to the drama.

MIRZA:

Listen, Ahmad, right?

AHMAD:

Yes.

MIRZA:

(Appearing stern)

We all heard the story the Sergeant just said, the one about Amena. What do you think happened to all those soldiers? Do you think the vengeful spirit of Amena is roaming around killing the people who had wronged her?

AHMAD:

(confused)

Well... I...

MIRZA:

It's the Bangalees. The Mukti-Bahini or whatever the hell they call themselves. Amena was most likely an informant. She got caught, got interrogated, and then killed. And now, the Bangalees are here tying up loose ends. There's no ghosts, just people trying to make sure their side wins this war. It's kill, or be killed.

If we spare them, they'll kill us. If they spare us, we'll kill them.

Such is war.

AHMAD:

(His voice betraying a slight tone of anger)

But... But yesterday, at the bazaar, those people weren't informants, they weren't fighters. They were just innocent civilians, just going about their day.

And we... and we killed them. And not just the men, but the women and the children too. They didn't even have the strength to fight back. They just stood there as we gunned them down as if they were insects. We didn't leave a single soul alive there, not even one!

And even if all that was really necessary, why did we have to kill the children?! They don't even know why we are killing them! I doubt they even know what "Bangladesh" means! So why? What wrong did they-

FARUK:

(interrupting AHMAD)

What wrong did they do us? (Mocking, angrily)

You absolute moron, open your eyes! What do you think these children are going to do when they grow up and learn what we did to their parents? Sit around and cry? No!

We had to kill all of them. Because had we missed a couple, they would have bred a couple more, and the next time, we would have to be fighting twice as many as before!

The confrontation escalates quickly, and neither party are willing to back down. AHMAD is about to counter FARUK's argument, but just then, JAVED and SALMAN step in to mediate the conflict and cool everyone down.

JAVED:

(In a friendly, yet commanding tone)

Faruk, Mirza, Ahmad- all of you, calm down!

I think that's enough philosophy for one day. And you two; just leave the poor kid alone. It's his first time in the frontlines, he's ought to be more than a little frustrated.

SALMAN:

Yeah, tone it down a bit, jeez. I brought him along with me to help him settle down, not to give him a reason to shoot you.

I can get why Ahmed's getting so worked up about it, but you should really know better Faruk.

There is a small pause and the silence gives everyone enough time to settle down. FARUK seems to sober up and appears slightly embarrassed for snapping at the young conscript who didn't know better. AHMAD also cools down and decides it's not worth it to antagonize himself to his comrades anymore.

FARUK:

Sorry buddy, lost my cool there.

AHMAD:

No worries, it happens, I understand.

With the conflict now resolved, and all disagreements mediated for the time being, SALMAN, visibly happy with himself for fixing the problem, tries (and succeeds) to steer the conversation away to lighter topics.

SALMAN:

Ah well, now that that's over, I say it'd be best if we stay away from the more sensitive topics, okay fellas?

MIRZA:

Sounds good to me!

Say, Faruk, got any other stories about how you missed a headshot at point blank range?

FARUK:

Oh, come on! Not this again!

The group returns to its silly, gleeful state. AHMAD seems to have shaken off his initial depressed mood, and begins to actively participate in the conversation. The camera slowly pans away from the

group, and we can see that everyone is having a good time, even though we can not hear anything they are saying.

-FADE OUT

SCENE 2

EXT. OPEN FIELD, BANGLADESH, JULY 1971-LATE NIGHT/BEFORE DAWN

It has been several hours since the last scene, and the characters are still sitting around the fire. It is nearing the end of their shift, and everyone is a little tired compared to their selves from the first scene. A faint sound of a woman crying can be heard, originating from the nearby village.

SALMAN:

Is that the sound of someone... crying?

JAVED:

Well, good to know I wasn't the only one hearing it.

AHMAD:

Sounds like a woman.

FARUK:

Yeah, no kidding.

AHMAD:

She sounds like she's in distress.

FARUK:

Well, too bad.

AHMAD:

Shouldn't we like... try to help her? Or at the very least, go check it out? I mean, we are lookouts afterall...

MIRZA:

Are you kidding me? After that entire lecture, you still want to go and rescue a Bangalee?

Like seriously?

FARUK:

(Sighing)

It's like you didn't listen to a single word I said, kiddo.

SALMAN:

(Annoyed)

Oh for God's sake! Stop over-reacting for once and just let the damn kid do what he wants; even if it is fulfilling his "saving the damsel-in-distress" fantasy!

JAVED:

Hate to say it, but Salman's probably right.

AHMAD:

(Surprised)

So... we're all actually going to save that woman?

AHMAD gets up and arms himself with his weapon and other gear. JAVED takes a look around the group and realizes that no one else is even a little bit enthusiastic about the prospect of getting up. They are simply too tired. JAVED sighs once he realizes what he has to do as the superior officer. And then he gets up too, and begins readying his gear.

JAVED:

Nope, only the two of us. And first of all, we need to confirm that it actually is, a woman, before we get to the saving part.

SALMAN:

Woo! Way to go sergeant!

FARUK:

You can be like his new father figure now! (Everyone laughs)

JAVED:

(Playful)

Just shut up and Keep the fire warm for us till we get back, okay? Come on, kid, let's go.

The duo of JAVED and AHMED walk away from the group and begin making their way towards the unlit village in the distance.

CUT TO:

SCENE 3**EXT. UNINHABITED VILLAGE, BANGLADESH, JULY 1971-LATE NIGHT/DAWN**

JAVED and AHMAD are making their way to the source of the sound. The crying seems a lot louder now, and it closely resembles that of a woman in unbearable pain. However, the entire village appears deserted. Their only source of light are their two electric torches and whatever little moonlight still was present. AHMAD appears worried, while JAVED seems alert.

AHMAD:

The village seems uninhabited from the looks of it.

JAVED:

Makes sense, everyone probably fled once the troops arrived.

AHMAD:

That's kinda odd though. What would a woman be doing alone out here then? How would she even get here? And that too at this hour of the night?

AHMAD and JAVED inch closer to the hut with the wailing woman. And as soon as they reach the hut, the crying disintegrates, and within seconds, they find themselves in complete silence.

JAVED:

Hmmm... Odd indeed.

Stay on guard, and keep your rifle at the ready.

Pretty sure this is a trap.

AHMAD:

Wait, a trap?! What do you mean a trap?

But JAVED does not answer. He enters the dark, abandoned hut with his rifle raised, and torch aimed. AHMAD is left outside and ordered to watch the rear, and cover JAVED if needed.

CUT TO:

INT. ABANDONED HUT, UNINHABITED VILLAGE, JULY 1971- EARLY DAWN

We follow JAVED into the hut, leaving the fate of AHMAD uncertain for the time being. JAVED searches the interior of the hut, and to his surprise, finds nothing. Further inspection reveals no traps or back doors. But just as JAVED was about to turn back and head out, he feels someone breathing on his shoulder. The room is extremely dark, and so it's not possible for the camera to see what is behind him either.

JAVED turns around in a panic.

JAVED:

Who's there?! Show yourself!

There is no response, just him and the pitch black hut illuminated by only the dim light of his torch. Yet, he waits a couple of seconds. Still no response. This worries him, because at the very least, AHMAD should have responded. He calls out for AHMAD specifically this time.

JAVED:

Ahmad?!

Again, JAVED is greeted with only silence. He begins to make his way out of the abandoned cottage. And just as he is about to do so, he hears AHMAD gasp loudly, followed by the sound of at least two people running away.

CUT TO:

EXT. ABANDONED HUT, UNINHABITED VILLAGE, JULY 1971-EARLY DAWN

JAVED runs out of the cottage to find the door unguarded and AHMAD nowhere to be seen. His rifle and torch, however, can be seen lying on the ground near the door.

JAVED:

(Muttering to himself)

Where the hell did he run off to?

Suddenly the deafening silence of the uninhabited and pitch black village is broken with the sound of gunshots, fired from approximately where the group had been camping out. More gunshots follow, along with the distant screams of SALMAN, FARUK and MIRZA. JAVED panics, and begins running in the direction of his comrades.

JAVED:

This can't be happening! Gunshots?! Who are they shooting at?

Bangalees? Has to be... So, it WAS a trap!

But how the hell did those devils know we'd be camping out here? There's no way they could know about it... Unless...

Before JAVED can finish his train of thought, he hears the voice of AHMAD call out to him from somewhere in the dark. Dawn is yet to break, so visibility is still extremely limited. He turns his torch in the direction of the voice to see the crouched figure of AHMAD, sitting in front of an abandoned hut. JAVED is enraged as he believes

AHMAD is a spy for the Bangladeshis. JAVED points his rifle towards the crouched figure of AHMAD.

AHMAD:

S...Sergeant?

JAVED:

You!

It was you, you rat-bastard!

You traitor! You betrayed us and Pakistan!

Because of you, all of my friends are now dead!

How could you do this to us! How could you do this to Salman?!
After everything we did for you?!

AHMAD:

...

JAVED:

(Yelling in rage)

What? Forgot how to speak again?!

In that case, let me remind you!

JAVED shoots the ground near to where AHMAD is sitting, in the hopes that it might scare AHMAD into speaking. But AHMAD remains silent, not even flinching when the bullet hits the ground. JAVED is taken aback. He looks closely at AHMAD's face and realizes he looks different. He looks incredibly pale, as if all the blood had been sucked out of his body. AHMAD stares directly at JAVED, in an unbroken gaze, his face revealing hints of disgust.

JAVED:

Speak goddammit! What the hell did you do?

AHMAD:

(slowly)

You were there that day, weren't you?

JAVED:

What?

AHMAD: (V.O)

You said a couple of guys from your unit in Tangail held that girl captive, and then did all kinds of unspeakable shit to her, before tossing her away like trash. And you only got to know about it after the fact.

But that was a lie.

You were one of them. And you thought you could just keep that as *your little secret*.

You were there when they captured her. You were there when they... when they violated her until there was nothing left to be ravaged.

And you were there when they decapitated whatever remained of her body.

You were there- through every sick, despicable part of the way.

And when the killings started, you got scared and got yourself posted here, like a filthy coward. You were one of them, weren't you?

INTERCUT WITH:

EXT. DESTROYED VILLAGE, TANGAIL, APRIL 1971-DAY

A group of soldiers, JAVED among them, forcefully takes a woman along with them. The woman is bound and in shackles. In the background, the ruins of her village can be clearly seen, as well as the numerous dead bodies and remains of the villagers.

EXT. PAKISTAN ARMY BARACKS, TANGAIL, APRIL 1971-DAY

The same group of soldiers, along with JAVED, is taking that same woman into their barracks. The scene ends as the doors to the barracks close, once all the characters are inside.

EXT. RIVER BANK, TANGAIL, MAY 1971-NIGHT

The desecrated body of the woman can be seen. A couple of soldiers are packing her severed head into a sack to dispose of it. Another soldier is pushing her headless body into the river. His back is to the camera, and so we can not see who this soldier is. Once the body has been disposed of, the soldier turns around to reveal that he is in fact JAVED.

CUT BACK TO:

EXT. ABANDONED HUT, UNINHABITED VILLAGE, JULY 1971-DAWN

JAVED is horrified by AHMAD's words. The gunshots in the distance have died down. The screams from their comrades too have now subsided. It is implied that they are no longer alive. It is still fairly dark, but the sun is slowly starting to rise. JAVED aims his rifle directly at AHMAD's head.

JAVED:

(Petrified)

I... I don't understand where this is coming from?! What is wrong with you? Why are you doing this? And what the hell does any of that have to do with whatever in God's name is happening now?!

AHMAD:

(In a monotonous voice)

She is here for you.

JAVED:

What is that supposed to mean?! The Bangalees are here, not some dead wench!

AHMAD remains silent. The grim realization dawns on JAVED.

JAVED:

(Yelling)

And why should I believe anything you say? You're just a lying piece of shit!

I should just kill you right here, right now! **AHMAD:**

(In the same monotonous voice)

Oh please, please kill me.

She said she'd be back for me once she's done with the others. And I do not want to be here when that-

AHMAD's voice trails off as he stares in wide eyed terror at something behind JAVED. The sounds of a woman's anklet can be heard. The camera cuts to such a position that it reveals JAVED's horror-stricken face. Behind him, in the faint light, the silhouette of a headless woman can barely be deduced. The figure seems to be carrying a medium sized sack in one of her hands. The calm, almost happy, voice of a woman begins permeating from that sack.

AMENA:

(softly)

Oh Javed!

Good to see you again!

CUT TO BLACK

END.